

● HARD

● INFORMATION AND IDEAS

Central Ideas and Details

10 questions · ~15 min

04

The following text is Vita Sackville-West's circa 1920 poem "Evening." Spars are ships' masts, moorings are ropes that hold docked ships in place, and a riding-light is a light that a ship shines when it is anchored.

When little lights in little ports come out,
Quivering down through water with the stars,
And all the fishing fleet of slender spars
Range at their moorings, veer with tide about;

When race of wind is stilled and sails are furled,
And underneath our single riding-light
The curve of black-ribbed deck gleams palely white,
And slumbrous waters pool a slumbrous world;

—Then, and then only, have I thought how sweet
Old age might sink upon a windy youth,
Quiet beneath the riding-light of truth,
Weathered through storms, and gracious in retreat.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. The tranquility of a port in the evening can incline a person to appreciate the stillness of old age.
- B. The difficulty of bringing a ship into port is apt training for dealing with the types of struggles encountered in old age.

- C. A person who leads a long life that is varied and active may find it difficult to stay in a calm place.
- D. The contrast between the peacefulness of a port at night and its activity during the day reflects the contrast between the calm of old age and the vibrancy of youth.

Modern dog breeds are largely the result of 160 years of owners crossbreeding certain dogs in order to select for particular physical appearances. Owners often say that some breeds are also more likely than others to have particular personality traits—basset hounds are affectionate; boxers are easy to train—but Kathleen Morrill and colleagues found through a combination of owner surveys and DNA sequencing of 2,000 dogs that while physical traits are predictably heritable among purebred dogs, behavior varies widely among dogs of the same breed.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Dog breeds would not exist without many years of human intervention in dogs' reproduction.
- B. Research fails to confirm a commonly held belief about dog breeds and behavior.
- C. The dog breeds most popular among owners have often changed over the past 160 years.
- D. A study of dog breeds is notable for its usage of both opinion surveys and DNA sequencing.

Algae living within the tissues of corals play a critical role in keeping corals, and the marine ecosystems they are part of, thriving. Some coral species appear brown in color when healthy due to the algae colonies living in their tissues. In the event of an environmental stressor, the algae can die or be expelled, causing the corals to appear white. To recover the algae, the bleached corals then begin to produce bright colors, which block intense sunlight, encouraging the light-sensitive algae to recolonize the corals.

What does the text most strongly suggest about corals that produce bright colors?

- A. These corals have likely been subjected to stressful environmental conditions.
- B. These corals are likely more vulnerable to exposure from intense sunlight than white corals are.
- C. These corals have likely recovered from an environmental event without the assistance of algae colonies.
- D. These corals are more likely to survive without algae colonies than brown corals are.

Disco remains one of the most ridiculed popular music genres of the late twentieth century. But as scholars have argued, the genre is far less superficial than many people believe. Take the case of disco icon Donna Summer: she may have been associated with popular songs about love and heartbreak (subjects hardly unique to disco, by the way), but like many Black women singers before her, much of her music also reflects concerns about community and identity. These concerns are present in many of the genre's greatest songs, and they generally don't require much digging to reveal.

What does the text most strongly suggest about the disco genre?

- A. It has been unjustly ignored by most scholars despite the importance of the themes addressed by many of the genre's songs.
- B. It evolved over time from a superficial genre focused on romance to a genre focused on more serious concerns.
- C. It has been unfairly dismissed for the inclusion of subject matter that is also found in other musical genres.
- D. It gave rise to a Black women's musical tradition that has endured even though the genre itself faded in the late twentieth century.

In a study of new technology adoption, Davit Marikyan et al. examined negative disconfirmation (which occurs when experiences fall short of one's expectations) to determine whether it could lead to positive outcomes for users. The team focused on established users of "smart home" technology, which presents inherent utilization challenges but tends to attract users with high expectations, often leading to feelings of dissonance. The researchers found that many users employed cognitive mechanisms to mitigate those feelings, ultimately reversing their initial sense of disappointment.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. Research suggests that most users of smart home technology will not achieve a feeling of satisfaction given the utilization challenges of such technology.
- B. Although most smart home technology is aimed at meeting or exceeding users' high expectations, those expectations in general remain poorly understood.
- C. Research suggests that users with high expectations for a new technology can feel content with that technology even after experiencing negative disconfirmation.
- D. Although negative disconfirmation has often been studied, little is known about the cognitive mechanisms shaping users' reactions to it in the context of new technology adoption.

The following text is adapted from Fanny Burney's 1778 novel *Evelina*. The text is an excerpt from a letter by Lady Howard to Evelina's guardian, Reverend Villars, in which Lady Howard discusses an upcoming trip to London planned by her daughter Mrs. Mirvan's family.

It is very earnestly [the Mirvans'] wish to enlarge and enliven their party by the addition of your amiable ward, who would share, equally with her own daughter, the care and attention of Mrs. Mirvan. Do not start at this proposal; it is time that [Evelina] should see something of the world. When young people are too rigidly sequestered from it, their lively and romantic imaginations paint it to them as a paradise of which they have been beguiled; but when they are shown it properly, and in due time, they see it such as it really is, equally shared by pain and pleasure, hope and disappointment.

Based on the text, Lady Howard would most likely agree with which statement about Reverend Villars?

- A. Although the manner in which he has raised Evelina is in many ways exemplary, he has been misguided in shielding her from the influence of other young people.
- B. He has imparted to Evelina his own idealistic view of the world, which results in her being unprepared to face inevitable disappointments.
- C. Although his desire to guard Evelina from unscrupulous people is commendable, his general mistrust has led him to be unduly wary of the Mirvans.
- D. He is overly protective of Evelina, who would likely benefit from a greater variety of experiences than she has had thus far.

In 2019, 20 previously unknown moons were confirmed to be orbiting Saturn. Three of the moons have prograde orbits (orbiting in the direction the planet spins), and the other 17 have retrograde orbits (orbiting in the opposite direction of the planet's spin). All but one of the 20 moons are thought to be remnants of bodies that orbited Saturn until they broke apart in collisions. Although the one exceptional moon orbits in the same direction as the planet's spin, its orbit is highly eccentric compared to the rest, which may suggest that it has a different origin than the other 19 moons.

Based on the text, which choice best describes the moon with the eccentric orbit?

- A. It doesn't have a retrograde orbit, but it likely has the same origin as the moons with retrograde orbits.
- B. Its orbit is so tilted with respect to the other moons' orbits that it's neither prograde nor retrograde.
- C. It has a prograde orbit that is likely the result of having collided with another body orbiting Saturn.
- D. It has a prograde orbit and may not be a remnant of an earlier body that orbited Saturn.

The following text is from Mick Herron’s 2023 novel *The Secret Hours*. The narrator is describing members of a government committee.

Finally, and adding much-needed gravitas, was Sir Winston Day, whose features seemed moulded to adorn a bust, or possibly a stamp, and whose forehead was so evidently bulging with grey matter that it would have been impertinent to inquire too closely into the actual achievements his half century of public service had produced. His recently published memoirs possibly cast light on this enigma, but given that such details were not provided until after the thirty-page mark, they might as well have remained state secrets.

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Based on the text, which choice best describes Sir Winston Day?

- A. He has the appearance of a distinguished figure, but it is uncertain whether he has accomplished anything to earn distinction.
- B. He looks like a person worthy of respect, but his memoirs reveal that some of his actions were dishonorable.
- C. He would be a celebrated public figure if his achievements did not have to be kept secret.
- D. He has maintained a modest profile even though he has served the public capably for many years.

Philosophers note that many people have an intuitive sense that while we ought not to lie, there may be circumstances in which lying is permissible. If this intuition is correct and we lack an inviolable duty to speak truthfully, what grounds opposition to lying in the first place? Japa Pallikkathayil has advanced one answer by appealing to a duty to respect others' agential interests: the possession of false beliefs constrains agency, and thus we ought not to impede the formation of true beliefs unless doing so prevents a greater constraint on someone's agency or an otherwise impermissible end.

Which choice best states the main idea of the text?

- A. One potential means of justifying opposition to lying is Pallikkathayil's argument that we have an obligation to respect other people's agency that entails a commitment to truthfulness except in certain circumstances.
- B. Many people have an intuitive sense that lying is permissible in some circumstances but lack a principled way to identify those circumstances, and Pallikkathayil's argument may provide a means of resolving that problem.
- C. Pallikkathayil's argument suggests that if we have a duty to respect other people's agential interests and if possession of false beliefs constrains agency, then we have an inviolable duty to speak truthfully.
- D. Pallikkathayil's argument shows that if our intuition that circumstances may make lying permissible is correct, then it is unclear whether there are any grounds for an opposition to lying in the first place.

The most recent iteration of the immersive theater experience *Sleep No More*, which premiered in New York City in 2011, transforms its performance space—a five-story warehouse—into a 1930s-era hotel. Audience members, who wander through the labyrinthine venue at their own pace and follow the actors as they play out simultaneous, interweaving narrative loops, confront the impossibility of experiencing the production in its entirety. The play’s refusal of narrative coherence thus hinges on the sense of spatial fragmentation that the venue’s immense and intricate layout generates.

What does the text most strongly suggest about *Sleep No More*’s use of its performance space?

- A. The choice of a New York City venue likely enabled the play’s creators to experiment with the use of theatrical space in a way that venues from earlier productions could not.
- B. Audience members likely find the experience of the play disappointing because they generally cannot make their way through the entire venue.
- C. The production’s dependence on a particular performance environment would likely make it difficult to reproduce exactly in a different theatrical space.
- D. Audience members who navigate the space according to a recommended itinerary will likely have a better grasp of the play’s narrative than audience members who depart from that itinerary.